REQDECK

Your first API requests

A friendly guide to ReqDeck for people who have never sent a request.



What is inside

1 Your first request in five minutes

2 What a request is made of

3 Variables and environments

4 Logging in: authentication

5 Reading the answer

6 History and cURL

7 Your data

8 Coming from Postman

9 When something does not work

★ Keys worth knowing

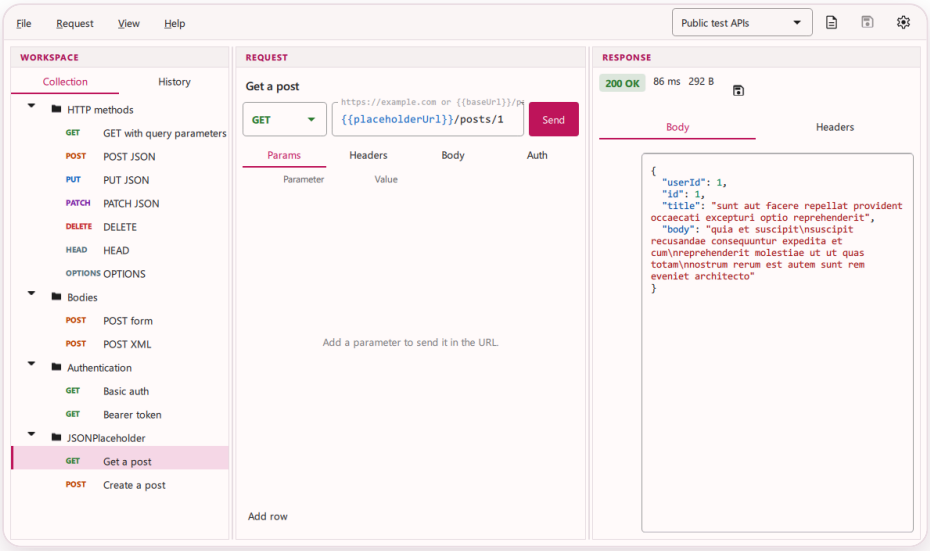
↗ Places to practice

CHAPTER 1

Your first request in five minutes

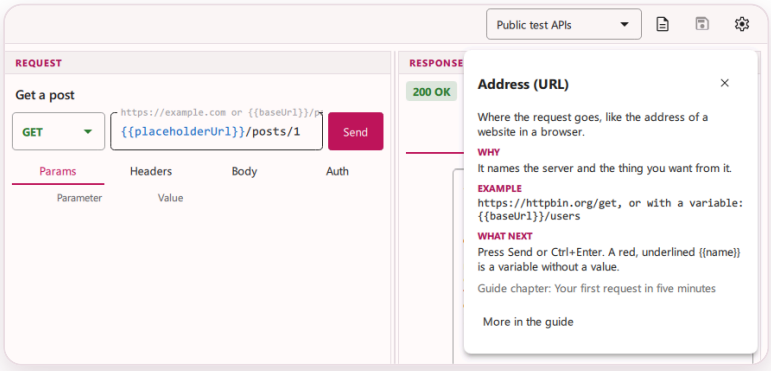
A request is a message your computer sends to a server. The server answers with a response. That is all an API is: a server that answers requests from programs instead of from people with a browser.

1. Start ReqDeck and choose Open Samples.
2. ReqDeck opens the request "Get a post" from the folder JSONPlaceholder in the Collection on the left.
3. Look at the address in the middle: this is where the request goes.
4. Press Send, or `Ctrl+Enter`.
5. On the right you see the answer: a green 200 OK and the post as JSON.



A request in the middle, its answer on the right.

> **Tip**
>
> Not sure what something is? Point at it and press `F1`.



Press `F1` and ReqDeck explains what is under the pointer.

CHAPTER 2

What a request is made of

Think of a request as a letter. The method is what you ask for, the address is where it goes, parameters and headers are notes on the envelope, and the body is the letter inside.

GET	Read something. No body.
POST	Create something new. Usually with a body.
PUT / **PATCH**	Change something that exists.
DELETE	Remove something.

Parameters are added to the address after a question mark, for example ?page=2. Headers carry information about the request, such as the format you accept. The body carries data, most often as JSON.



A JSON body for a POST request.

Tip

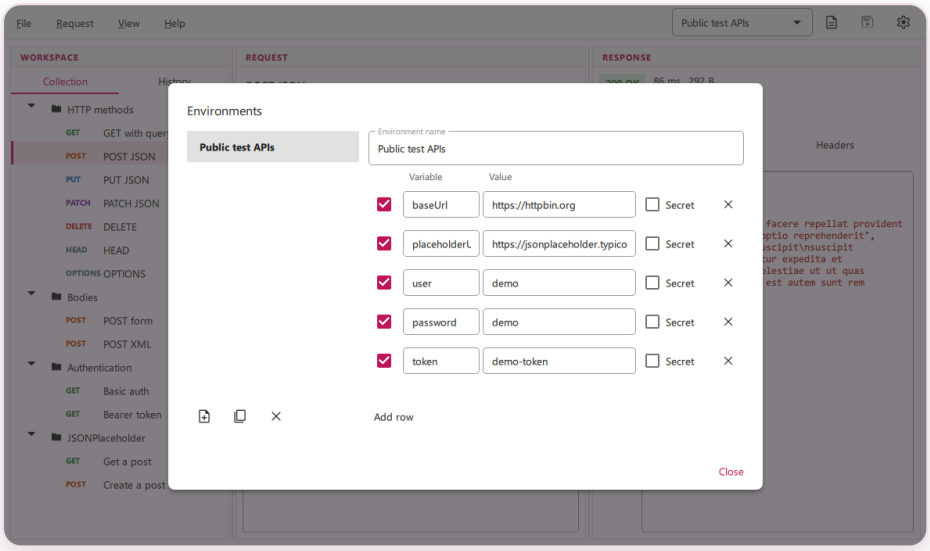
`Ctrl+K` finds any request by a few words of its name or address, and any menu command. In the tree, Ctrl+click or Shift+click selects several items, F2 renames, Delete deletes, and right-click > Sort A–Z orders a folder.

CHAPTER 3

Variables and environments

A variable is a name for a value you use in many requests. Write `{{baseUrl}}` instead of the full server address, and change the address in one place.

An environment is a set of variables. Make one for each server, for example Staging and Production, and switch between them at the top of the window.



Environments and their variables.

Tip

A `{{name}}` in red with an underline has no value in the active environment.

Careful

Tick Secret for passwords and keys. Their values are then kept out of the workspace file.

Tip

A field that names a variable the active environment does not have gets a red frame. Point at the field to see which variable is missing.

Tip

Type {{ and ReqDeck lists the variables of the active environment; Enter inserts one. If a request uses a variable the environment lacks, Send asks for its value first.

CHAPTER 4

Logging in: authentication

Many APIs answer only to users they know. The Auth tab adds the proof to each request.

Basic	User name and password.
Bearer	A token the service gave you.
API key	A key, sent as a header or a parameter.

Careful
Use variables such as `{{token}}` with Secret ticked, so the value is not saved in the workspace file.

Tip
A password, token, or key you type into a request is saved in the workspace file. ReqDeck then offers Move to a secret: the value goes into a secret variable, encrypted on this computer, and the field shows `{{token}}` instead.

CHAPTER 5

Reading the answer

The first number tells whether the request worked. Codes starting with 2 mean success, with 4 a problem with the request, with 5 a problem on the server.

200 OK	It worked.
201 Created	Something new was created.
204 No Content	It worked; there is nothing to show.
400 Bad Request	The server did not understand the request. Check the body and parameters.
401 Unauthorized	You are not logged in, or the token expired.
403 Forbidden	You are logged in but not allowed.
404 Not Found	Nothing at this address. Check the URL.
429 Too Many Requests	Slow down and try later.
500 Internal Server Error	The server failed. Not your fault, usually.



Status, time, size, and the body of the answer.

Tip

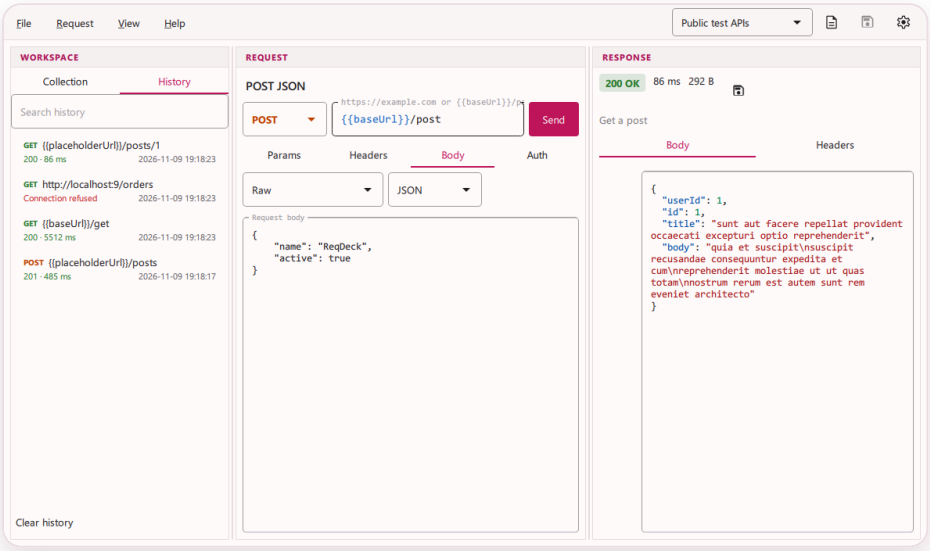
`Ctrl+F` finds text in the answer. The save button beside the size writes the answer to a file, also a very large one, of which only the start is shown.

CHAPTER 6

History and cURL

Every request you send lands in History, on the left. Double-click an entry to make a new request from it. Passwords and tokens written in a request are not kept there.

Documentation often shows requests as curl commands. Use File > Import cURL to turn one into a request, and Request > Copy as cURL to share yours.



History with the status of each request.

> **Tip**
> The search field above the history keeps the entries that contain every word you type, for example post orders.

CHAPTER 7

Your data

Your requests live in the workspace file you chose, a .reqdeck file you may copy or share. Secret values of environments are not in it: ReqDeck keeps them encrypted for your Windows user on this computer.

On another computer, or under another Windows user, the secret values are empty. ReqDeck says so when the workspace opens. Enter them again and save.

Before a new version changes the format of these files, ReqDeck keeps a copy of the workspace file and its secret values. File > Restore Previous Copy puts them back; changes made since then are lost.

Tip

Two ReqDeck windows can run at once: both add to the same history.

CHAPTER 8

Coming from Postman

You do not have to start again. ReqDeck reads the files Postman, Insomnia, and API descriptions give you, and turns them into a folder of requests.

1. In Postman, export the collection as Collection v2.1, and each environment you need. In Insomnia, use Export Data with the Insomnia v4 (JSON) format. For an API description, take its openapi.json.
2. In ReqDeck, choose File > Import Collection… and pick the file.
3. Read the list of what does not carry over, then press Import.
4. Save the workspace with `Ctrl+S` to keep the new folder.

Postman collection	Folders, requests, headers, bodies, auth, and collection variables. The variables become settings of the new folder.
Postman environment	A new environment. Secret values come over empty: enter them again.
Insomnia export	The first workspace with its folders and requests. The base environment becomes folder variables, the other environments ReqDeck environments.
OpenAPI 3 document	One request per operation, in folders by tag, with example values. The server address becomes the variable `{{baseUrl}}`; with several servers, each one becomes an environment.

Auth set on a folder is used by every request in it whose auth is Inherit from folder. Right-click a folder and choose Folder Settings… to see or change it.

Careful

Scripts, tests, OAuth 2.0, file uploads, and generated values such as {{$guid}} do not carry over. ReqDeck never runs code from an imported file; the list before the import names each one, so you can redo it by hand.

Tip

Fill in the variables the import left empty, such as `{{token}}`, in Folder Settings… or in an environment.

CHAPTER 9

When something does not work

Connection refused	Nothing answers at this address. Is the server running? Is the port right?
Host not found	The server name is wrong or the network is down.
Timeout	The server took too long. Raise the timeout or try later.
Unresolved variable	A `{{name}}` has no value. Pick the right environment.
Certificate error	The server's HTTPS certificate is not trusted, common on test servers. If you know the server, press Continue.
Proxy or company network	ReqDeck uses the proxy set in Windows, like your browser. Requests to your own computer always go directly.
Secret values are empty on another computer	Secret values are encrypted for your Windows user on the computer where you saved them. On another computer or user, enter them again and save. The workspace file itself is not affected.

Tip
View > Show Log Panel shows what ReqDeck did and what went wrong.

Keys worth knowing

`F1`	Explain what is under the pointer or in the field you type in.
`Ctrl` + `Enter`	Send the request.
`Ctrl` + `K`	Find a request or a command.
`Ctrl` + `S`	Save the workspace.
`Ctrl` + `N`	Add a new request.
`Ctrl` + `O`	Open a workspace.
`F2`	Rename the selected item in the tree.
`Esc`	Close the help or a dialog.

Places to practice

https://httpbin.org
A free public API that answers whatever you send. Safe to experiment on.

https://developer.mozilla.org/docs/Web/HTTP/Status
Every HTTP status code explained.